

Chapter 143 - Missing

Ning Fuyi didn't cry for long. She soon pulled herself together and buried herself in the Scripture Pavilion, wanting to search through the vast sea of ancient texts for even a trace of clues about the bottle. She spent the entire night like this.

The Scripture Pavilion had no windows, so she didn't know when dawn came. She just forgot to eat and sleep, closing one book and picking up another.

The door opened, and a red-robed woman walked in carrying a precarious mountain of books, struggling to close the door with her foot before dumping those bamboo slips and turtle shells heavily in front of her.

"These are what Xi Que sent—the oldest ancient texts the demon realm could find," Jiuying said, patting her sore arms and sitting cross-legged beside her.

"Thank you," Ning Fuyi said. She rubbed her bleary eyes and reached into the turtle shells to pick through them, taking out what looked like the oldest piece.

There were still bloodstains on the side—very much like something that should belong to the demon realm.

The writing on it was obscure and difficult to understand. Ning Fuyi compared it with books on ancient scripts, reading character by character before finally grasping the general meaning.

But it had nothing to do with the Jade Pure Bottle, so she casually tossed it aside.

"You've been looking all night. Rest a bit," Jiuying placed a pot of flower dew beside her face. "You don't need to be so anxious. Now the entire Six Realms are searching for the whereabouts of the Jade Pure Cloud-Opening Bottle. Perhaps there'll be news in a few days."

"How can I have the heart to rest?" Ning Fuyi sighed. "After searching for so long, only this 'Record of Eastern Hua's Cold Martial Arts' mentioned the Jade Pure Cloud-Opening Bottle."

"But it only described how powerful Nuwa's magical artifact was, without half a sentence about its whereabouts."

"In this vast world, finding a bottle is harder than fishing a needle from the sea," Jiuying scratched her head and picked up several bamboo slips to help her look.

Ning Fuyi flipped through two more books, then suddenly remembered something: "Have you seen Qiu Yi these past few days?"

Jiuying looked up from the dim candlelight: "No, I thought she'd been following the Divine Venerable."

Ning Fuyi nodded thoughtfully, recalling the drunken words Qiu Yi had said to her on her birthday. At the time, she thought they were just drunken ramblings, but now, thinking back, she always felt something was amiss.

"These past few days, I've been practically glued to Chu Qingqiu—I would have crawled into her consciousness if I could—but I haven't seen any trace of Qiu Yi," Ning Fuyi said, continuing to flip through the books.

But her heart felt like it was suspended by an invisible thread, not quite at peace.

"Bird probably went somewhere to have fun," Jiuying touched her red-painted nails to her lips, not paying much attention.

"Jiuying, what do you think of Qiu Yi?" Ning Fuyi asked suddenly. She wasn't slow when it came to emotions—her thoughts were even more delicate than Chu Qingqiu's, so she had noticed early on.

It was only after that night of drunken conversation that she became certain.

Jiuying couldn't understand the bamboo slip in her hands, so she set it aside and picked up one that was more comprehensible, reading while answering: "She's always been very afraid of me."

"Perhaps it's because I once led her into a trap as a demon beast, and bound her for two days, which frightened her," Jiuying shrugged. "But don't let her chattering fool you—her heart is actually pure, and despite her small body, she has the righteousness of the clouds."

Ning Fuyi couldn't tell whether she was talking about Qiu Yi as a person or as a parrot.

Later she realized that given Jiuying's towering appearance after transformation, she would probably see any of them as small creatures.

So she smiled.

"There's nothing here either," Jiuying sighed and tossed the bamboo slip aside.

Just then the door opened again. Wind passed through the doorway, making all the book pages rustle loudly. The fragrance of flowers replaced the scent of ink, and Ning Fuyi didn't need to look up to know who it was.

"Are you finished with these?" Jiuying suddenly stood up, gathering the books they'd read into her arms. "I'll help you put them back."

With that, she gracefully walked past Chu Qingqiu, gave her a charming smile, and left with the fragrant breeze.

Chu Qingqiu saw Ning Fuyi's weary expression and immediately felt helpless. She closed the door and quickly walked to her, taking the ancient text from her hands: "You've been here all night?"

"Just one night—it's nothing," Ning Fuyi looked up at her. "I always feel like there might still be hope."

Chu Qingqiu's expression was silent as she placed the book on the shelf.

"Is something wrong?" Ning Fuyi saw her poor complexion and asked softly.

"Can't I come find you without something being wrong?" Chu Qingqiu said, turning to lift her skirt and sit beside her.

"Of course you can," Ning Fuyi smiled, reaching for another book, but her wrist was grasped by Chu Qingqiu, forcefully pulled back and held at her side.

"I miss you," Chu Qingqiu suddenly said.

Ning Fuyi's heart jumped along with her eyelashes. Thinking she had misheard, she perked up her ears: "What did you say?"

"I said, I missed you," Chu Qingqiu repeated, her voice low and gentle.

Ning Fuyi had been absent since yesterday afternoon. Normally, Chu Qingqiu wouldn't mind.

Just meditate, sleep, and these few hours would fly by like they had wings. But this day was different. She sat alone in the wind-blown pavilion at the heart of Tranquil Mountain Palace's lake, her heart filled only with melancholy.

Hearing the wind, she thought Ning Fuyi had returned and would always look up toward the palace gates. Seeing it was just wind moving the door latch, her melancholy only deepened.

At first she thought perhaps it was just habit from having Ning Fuyi's company these past days. But as the sun set and the moon rose high, the book in her hands hadn't absorbed even half a word, and only then did she realize this wasn't mere habit.

It was longing.

If someone had told her in the past that she would one day be so unable to part from another person, she would never have believed it.

It was only half a day, yet Chu Qingqiu stared blankly at the lake's unmarked surface, her heart filled with loneliness.

Loneliness without her company.

Ning Fuyi's consistently low spirits surged instantly because of her words "I missed you."

Chu Qingqiu wasn't good at expressing her thoughts. Being able to say such words could make Ning Fuyi bloom with joy, immediately giving her the impulse to give her anything.

"It's futile anyway—stop looking," Chu Qingqiu said. "Stay with me, Ning Fuyi."

She suddenly turned and embraced Ning Fuyi's neck, resting her face on her shoulder, holding each other among the towering bookshelves of the Scripture Pavilion.

Warm, soft arms around her neck, heat rising. Ning Fuyi raised her hands and gently lifted her, moving her entire body onto her lap.

Chu Qingqiu hesitated at first, then didn't refuse, curling up into a ball as she sat in her embrace.

This position was familiar—they had often been like this during their time in the mortal realm. But since Chu Qingqiu had returned to being the Divine Venerable, this position was no longer quite appropriate.

But now such external concerns were no longer important.

Ning Fuyi raised her hand, and her wide sleeves covered the person entirely. She lowered her head slightly to kiss Chu Qingqiu's hair, her nose tilting as the kiss slid down her forehead.

Slowly finding her lips, she kissed her deeply.

Chu Qingqiu let out a soft hum. Her hands tried to slide down from her shoulders, but Ning Fuyi pressed them back up, wanting her to embrace her just as before, until the kiss ended.

Chu Qingqiu's eyes were filled with flowing light, her breathing irregular. She smiled and buried her head back in her shoulder, hiding the blush on her cheeks.

"Yiyi, carry me back to Tranquil Mountain Palace," she said, bent over and speaking in muffled tones.